

Every review on the page is a rave

7 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

Nothing but five-star reviews and no criticism at all can be a red flag as easily as a good sign. The same unbroken pattern shows up when a listing is honestly popular, and when its reviews were bought.

THE GOAL

You're trying to judge whether this rating reflects real buyers, not just its average. Check how the reviews arrived before you trust the stars.

CHECKLIST

You're scrolling a listing's reviews, every one of them glowing and nothing critical anywhere, and your cursor is drifting toward the buy button.

- ☐ Sort the reviews to see the oldest ones first, instead of the page's default order, and skim how the first few were rated.
- ☐ If most of the five-star reviews landed within the same few days, go look for this item reviewed on a different site before buying.
- ☐ If there's no critical review anywhere, even among hundreds, look for other reviews of the same seller on a different site before deciding.
- ☐ If the page lets you open reviewer profiles, open two or three and check whether each one has reviewed anything besides this.
- ☐ Read one long review fully. If it spends most of its words on the reviewer's own story rather than the product, set it aside.
- ☐ Count how many reviews mention a free or discounted product, and see how many five-star ratings are left once you take those out.
- ☐ Search the product or seller's name together with a specific detail from a review, on a different site than this one.
- ☐ Look for the same sentence or phrase repeated across more than one review, and set those reviews aside.
- ☐ If this is an expensive or safety-related purchase, give yourself a longer check, say until tomorrow, before you decide.
- ☐ Count how many things gave you pause: the dates, the unanimity, the profiles, the wording. Two or more means hold off. None means go ahead.
- ☐ If you decide to buy anyway, check the return window before you pay, so you already know it if you need it.
- ☐ Save a screenshot of the listing and its reviews to your phone or notes, in case you need to show what convinced you.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Once a rating looks good, you judge its reviews less evenly: the glowing ones simply feel truer.
- 2 In an experiment, an early positive vote on a comment stuck uncorrected; an early negative vote got corrected toward fair.
- 3 A pile of good reviews can still hide manipulation. Some of the best-reviewed listings still buy more.

How a page ends up looking unanimous without anyone faking it

KNOW

Once a rating looks good, you judge its reviews less evenly: the glowing ones simply feel truer.

The high average sets your expectation first, so reviews that match it feel truer than ones that would make you doubt it. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

In an experiment, an early positive vote on a comment stuck uncorrected; an early negative vote got corrected toward fair.

Other people voting afterward rarely push a good start back down, but they do correct a start that's unfairly low. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

In that experiment, an early positive vote made later voters more likely to also vote positive, compounding for months.

An early positive vote made later voters about a third more likely to also vote positive, building up over months. [Source 2](#)

What the numbers on the page don't rule out

KNOW

A pile of good reviews can still hide manipulation. Some of the best-reviewed listings still buy more.

Checked listings included many already carrying lots of reviews and high ratings, not just new sellers trying to build a reputation from scratch. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

Reviews a platform later removes as fake skew overwhelmingly five-star rather than spreading evenly across ratings.

Sellers buying reviews are buying a higher rating, so what they add is almost always glowing, and that's what later gets caught. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

Trust in a rating peaks around 4.2 to 4.5 stars, then drops as the average nears perfect.

A few negative reviews mixed in make the good ones feel authentic, which a page full of praise never offers. [Source 4](#)

WATCH

A listing with no criticism at all isn't the safe bet it looks like: fraud investigators flag that pattern as a reason to look twice.

So when a listing has no critical reviews at all, check the same seller's reviews on a different site before deciding. [Source 5](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

If you read a review carefully and think critically about it, you can tell whether it's fake.

ACTUALLY

Being careful or thinking critically doesn't move the needle much: people specifically trained to catch fake reviews still did no better than a coin flip. [Source 6](#)

Sources

1. <https://scholars.hkbu.edu.hk/en/publications/when-do-consumers-value-positive-vs-negative-reviews-an-empirical/>
2. <https://snap.stanford.edu/class/cs224w-readings/muchnik13bias.pdf>
3. <https://eller.arizona.edu/sites/default/files/Hollenbeck%20Paper.pdf>
4. <https://spiegel.medill.northwestern.edu/star-ratings-and-review-content/>
5. <https://www.kktv.com/2022/06/20/five-star-fakes-fake-online-reviews-cheating-businesses-consumers/>
6. <https://news.cornell.edu/stories/2011/07/cornell-computers-spot-opinion-spam-online-reviews>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Reviews and ratings at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)